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Italy to approve 20,000 visas by December : foreign adviser

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Dhaka: Italy has pledged to process 20,000 pending visa applications for Bangladeshi nationals by December, said foreign adviser Md Touhid Hossain on Tuesday (Oct 8).

'As many as 20000 [visa] cases were cleared from Rome but the pace of issuing those [in Dhaka] is slow. I spoke with the Italian ambassador [in Dhaka] … he promised me that they will issue 20,000 visas by December,' he said.

According to foreign ministry, nearly 40,000 visa applications are pending at the Italian embassy.

The adviser shared the updates with reporters following a meeting with a delegation of Italian visa seekers at the foreign ministry.

Touhid said that apart from the cleared 20,000, they were also working

on the remaining applications and would see how much progress could be made.

‘To expedite the process, Italy has committed to reinforcing additional human resources at its embassy in Dhaka. The process is slow, but we hope it will pick up speed soon,’ he continued.

He also advised visa applicants to avoid protests or demonstrations, as these actions would not help accelerate the issuance process.

‘Issuing visas is the sovereign right of any country, and we cannot question why they haven’t granted a visa,’ the adviser said, adding that pressuring the Italian authorities could backfire and potentially jeopardise the entire visa programme.

Earlier, the Italian embassy in Dhaka had issued a statement urging applicants to refrain from submitting forged documents, emphasising that all applications would undergo rigorous scrutiny to prevent fraud.

The embassy reassured applicants that their ‘nulla osta’- the document issued by Italian immigration authorities allowing non-EU nationals to apply for a work visa - would not expire once an application or appointment request had been lodged.

The embassy, however, stressed that possessing a nulla osta did not guarantee visa approval, as all documents would be verified according to Italian laws.

Applicants were reminded of their right to appeal but were cautioned that decisions would be made strictly within Italy’s legal framework.

The Italian embassy reiterated its commitment to collaborating with Bangladeshi authorities and the European Union to prevent irregular migration and promote legal pathways.

Discussions on a bilateral agreement to improve migration and mobility issues are ongoing, with hopes for finalisation soon.

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